

1/1/25

11:13 PM

On New Year's Eve a door appeared in my apartment. In the hallway. It *looked* like the door to my room, but like, my room from before this apartment, from my, or, I guess my grandparents', house. Dark, reddish-brown wood, much prettier than the plain white one I use now, I think. In any case, there it was, right between the entrance and the bathroom. I went for the knob immediately of course, more reflex than anything I think, but before I even made contact, something slammed into the door from the other side (I can't guarantee that's what happened, but it certainly sounded like it). I'd flinched away in reaction, and was about to reach for it again when a voice called from behind it:

"Wait, hold on! Don't open the door, don't touch it if you can!"

Being a sensible person (I'd like to think, at least), I stopped and lowered my hand. Looking over the door again, I realized I'd missed a peephole—so it wasn't my door after all. It must've been some sort of mental-blindspot thing, where the door was so familiar at a glance I hadn't bothered taking in all the details. I hesitate to say I was relieved in that moment, but I'd certainly calmed down a bit. The knob looked scuffed exactly as I remembered it though, brass wearing away near its base; I do believe that once I feel it in my hands I'll know for sure, but again, being sensible, I'll hold off for now.

I left my bag against the couch and put some water on for tea, grabbed my journal from my room, then sat across the door to wait. Fireworks were starting up outside, so another thump like before wouldn't've startled me, wouldn't've bothered the neighbors—ideally, of course, though they weren't really that loud without the windows open, and it was cold enough already. The peephole stared down at me, and I had half a mind to stick some tape over it, but anyone

looking through would only see the wall when I was out anyway. I didn't know if that'd be safe either, didn't know if gloves would help. Doors don't just appear out of nowhere, and I wasn't going to be the person that ends up cursed or something for ignoring a warning.

The door sits flush against the ground too—another difference from mine. Mine had a notable gap, maybe half an inch or so? It's been years, but I swear it did. My hallway's fairly narrow, so I got a little (perhaps riskily) close to the door while lying down to check, but I managed just fine. I think I should stretch more often. I should also mention that, up close, the door smelled like my old one, as weird as that is. A bit like sand. I say that, but I can't realistically remember what that house smelled like. Years, etc. At the very least, it smelled different enough from the rest of my apartment to be noteworthy, familiar enough to make me believe that could be the case—as I live here now, my apartment has no smell to me. My tea was French vanilla though.

The new year came and went with no more voices from beyond the door, no sounds of any kind. I'll have to tack "be careful not to touch the door" onto my list of resolutions. And before the day passes: Happy New Year me! Let's have a good one.

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1/13/25

9:36 PM

Grocery run today. Stocked back up on tea and pasta, even though I've said I want to try making it from scratch more often. Aside from the usual stuff though, I got a new mug! Sure, I don't need it, but having another's always nice. Spice of life and all that, right? And for guests or something too, if I ever have any.

Speaking of guests, the door's still here. As much as something uninvited can be a guest, as much as a *door* can be. No sounds yet, but I think I'll try leaving an apple or croissant in front of it. Like an offering of sorts, but I'm not about to start treating it like a shrine or something, that'd be weird, and, if there is anything sinister going on, I'd probably be playing right into it. I'm thinking of it more like a mousetrap. I don't have an actual trap set up, but maybe I can leave a camera, or... I don't know, I don't have a camera, and just leaving my phone recording seems sort of dumb, to be honest. There's no way I'm staking it out myself, of course—I'm doing my best to remain cognizant of it, but I will *not* let it "take over my life" or something contrived like that. In fact, I think I'll go to bed early today. I do need the rest.

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1/25/25

7:52 PM

Finally got around to making pasta today! Took a while to get the dough feeling right (the first attempt came out way grainier than I'd like it), but I'd say it went pretty well overall. I've been making sauces myself for some time now, so being able to put together the other part of those meals with my own hands was really, really satisfying. It's also super tiring though, kneading the dough definitely counts as a whole workout for me. Hopefully I'll be able to first-try all my batches in the future.

I'm thinking about investing in a pasta extruder and laminator too, for those harder to make shapes. For now I've stuck to simple ones—trofie, tagliatelle, orecchiette (did still butcher a few of those, to be fair)—which are totally just as good, I'm not equating difficulty to quality or anything. And I'm sure there're cheaper, manual tools I could find for fancy shapes

too—guess it might be better to stick with the hands-on approach since this is all for myself. Automation is great, but I can do without it for now. I’m still going at it on paper here, after all. Though I do wish I could paste in a picture more easily, the new mug looks really nice next to the food—or maybe I’m still just proud of myself. Winter melon tea today, something fresh to keep me moving through all that strenuous labor.

Today’s entry is earlier than usual since I thought it was important to get down, and I also do want to sit back and relax with the rest of my dinner; doesn’t happen too often for me, but I might just go to sleep right after eating. I know there’re concerns about indigestion and all that, but, like I said, this isn’t routine for me, so. Should be safe, hopefully.

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2/6/25

9:44 PM

Got a call from Clem today, first one in quite a bit. He said he’ll be in the area these coming months, and will try to stop by at some point. We spent a good part of the night just catching up—not much in the way of “new” stuff for either of us, but chatting’s always fun. I mentioned my pasta endeavors, and he told me about how he’d actually been in Italy just two years ago. Promised pictures when he comes around too, but doesn’t have a concrete date yet. We agreed we should call more often, and yeah. I’ll have to get to spring cleaning early then.

Haven’t written about him, given how little we’ve seen of each other, but Clem’s a friend (probably now my only one, realistically) from when I was young. Not exactly a childhood friend, I don’t think we met until sometime in middle school, maybe? Not too sure, but there’s a lot to reminisce on. He was always kind of weird though; back then he had this, I’m not sure

what you'd call it, sort of like a motto? "Skipping, in all forms, as an art form" I'm pretty sure, and it's about exactly what it sounds like. He skipped everywhere he could, he *skipped* classes and events and stuff too. That's the kind of thing that, and I mean no offense here, I think I've mentioned it to him directly before, but that's the kind of thing that'd typically get you bullied as a kid, right? I mean, kids lock on to less bizarre things all the time. But, no, he was always fine. It's not like everyone loved him, he wasn't a class favorite or anything, people still got annoyed when he crashed into them in the halls, but—he was just too content. Never conceited, but very certain of how he went about things. Also helped that it was always fun to watch.

I was lucky enough to get a front-row seat on occasion too, he'd actually invited me along on some of his rock skipping sessions (I think it was a weekly thing for him, if I'm remembering right). We took a long bus ride out to near his usual lake, and on the way down from the stop, he, well, he half-skipped down to the lakeside? It was ridiculous then, and doubly ridiculous trying to explain it now, but he was committed to skipping all the time, and since he also needed to carefully scope out the area for rocks to use for skipping, he compromised by alternating between skipping and walking *every other minute*. And it must've been at least a mile from the stop to the lake too, not really all that close. I walked normally the whole way, obviously, and did my best to keep up.

By the time we got there, he'd picked up maybe six or seven rocks. I remember being surprised, and expecting more—though I will say, and this is a little silly, they looked very much like rocks meant to be skipped, top-quality, as it were—since he'd made it sound like this would be an afternoon-long activity. I couldn't imagine skipping a rock taking more than a couple seconds, and I wasn't wrong *per se*, but then he started meditating. Surprised again, though he did mention clearing his mind as part of the process. Between each and every throw, he sat down,

closed his eyes, and thought about nothing, I guess, for what felt like anywhere from ten to twenty minutes. I sat off to the side, and just enjoyed the scenery. It certainly was a beautiful lake, with enough flora around to stay bright, in a way, even under gray skies. There was a small island-formation a ways off, and that's where Clem told me he was aiming—he wanted to land a rock on that distant shore, wanted to be able to do so consistently.

I never saw him make it, and can't remember how many times I tagged along (only a handful, I think), but he was definitely improving each time. On the bus rides back, as the sun was setting, he'd pull out a journal and log the day's accomplishments while there was still light. That stuck with me, though it seems like everything has, really. It's probably why I have this habit now. A bit different from an actual plan or goal to work at, but it feels worthwhile all the same.

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2/17/25

8:58 PM

Cleaned out the apartment today, got everything in order, vacuumed, all that jazz. I found some stuff I'd forgotten about going through the closets—got a doormat from my old room, a yoga mat, and a little camping stove I used to mess around with. Full-on camping was never my thing, but I did enjoy reading outdoors, and having soup on hand enhances the experience tenfold. Maybe I'll take it out for a spin soon. The yoga mat definitely means something though; I tried to touch my toes the other day and, nope. So stretching routine, here I come. I tossed the doormat in front of the door (still here, still nothing). It's on the wrong side, but feels fitting anyway. I honestly don't know what to make of it at this point—there's nothing to say other than

nothing's happened. I don't know if it's waiting for me to slip up, or if I dreamt up the sounds from before, or if I'm currently still dreaming it up, and've been not touching the wall for no reason, but- I just don't know. I don't think there's anything I can reasonably do about it (not like I can call the police about a magic door), and it hasn't affected me at all, so it's fine, I guess. Routine. Anyway, there's stuff that's actually happening I should focus on.

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3/3/25

10:05 PM

Clem left a voicemail when I was out today, little update on his situation. Apparently he'd missed his layover the other week, and decided to wander around for a while before booking another flight. Never been to Chicago before, and thought he may as well take the chance to look around, soak up the culture. I left a message back, saying he should pick up some souvenirs for me while he's at it, a keychain, or maybe another mug. Pictures too, of course.

I'm thinking about bringing a mug with me on an outing soon—I'm having hot chocolate out of one of my older ones today—so all my things and I can get some fresh air. I'll have to plan out a meal too, and make a schedule to be sure I don't forget anything.

* * *

3/9/25

9:40 PM

Today I took the trip I'd planned out last week, though it got cut short, and I got a bit sidetracked. I arrived at the beach at around eleven, found a nice, shaded spot a ways off from

the actual sand, and settled down to read in the ocean breeze. I brought out my camping stove to make lunch at noon, and cooked up my leftover tagliatelle from yesterday. Fresh pasta by the ocean—it's good for the soul, I know it is. I didn't end up bringing a mug, but had a thermos of sweet iced tea instead, something less breakable. Everything was fine up till then, and for a while afterwards too—I laid down for a nap after lunch, and slept fairly well, better than I expected to on the ground, at least. Then I woke up to rain.

I hadn't packed an umbrella, since trusting the forecast is normal, but honestly, I may as well start, they're hardly a pound, I wouldn't even notice it. Having to pack a suitcase in the rain is something I'd like to avoid ever doing again. Sure, I probably looked weird wheeling it onto the beach, but *packing* it, I mean- I don't remember if there were still people around when I got up, maybe they'd all already left. Something something silver lining, I guess. The bus stop didn't have a canopy either, so I was just pulling a suitcase down the sidewalk in the rain like an insane person. I ducked into the first convenience store I could, kept ducking past the clerk, busied myself with looking over the snacks. It was just past three then, and the rain lasted another hour. I bought a magazine in the meantime.

Then I caught the wrong bus. Don't have much to say for myself about that. I was exhausted, but still. Didn't realize until after I'd stepped off, and the bus was headed the other direction anyway. This new bus stop had a canopy at least, but it wasn't raining anymore, so. All's well, right? I knew the neighborhood at least, my grandparents' house must've been only a couple blocks away. I thought about heading over, maybe I could check out my old room, see if the door was still there. I'm sure it is, but that could've been fun, nice, either or. I had no idea who lives there now though, and didn't want to intrude, or risk missing my bus again. Even so, I was considering it, to be sure. I'd been pacing up and down the sidewalk thinking it over, peering

over the rooftops to see if I could catch a glimpse—not that I’d even know what to look for. I sat back down, finished the magazine. It was getting a little chilly, and my hair was still damp. My footprints crossed over each other on the concrete, just barely visible. It was almost six. I got on the next bus, made sure it was the right one this time.

The door across from me is a snapshot of something I know—it hasn’t changed at all these past months. I’ll have to schedule another trip, soon if I can. I’m certain the house has been remodelled, repainted, revamped by now, and I think I’d still like to see it—not for closure, if that’s what I’m looking for, but just to *see it*. Something I don’t know. The straightest path to closure would be to just open the door, but I’m still set against that. There’s no pressure though, I’m just curious. I wonder if my room’s still being used, being lived in. I’ll have to bring a gift if I do visit though, call in advance too, probably. My shoes are a few feet away, leaning on the wall, drying. So’s my suitcase, a few umbrellas beside it. I’ve washed my clothes, taken a shower, and blow-dried my book a little. I dried my stove too, of course, but haven’t tried turning it on yet. I’m worried to see whether it still works—I’d like to think rain would wake me immediately, but at this point. Might as well get to it.

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3/28/25

9:19 PM

My digging’s finally yielded results! The people currently residing in my old house are a Mr. and Ms. Lark. I managed to get back out there to see the outside of the house in-person too (without messing up my buses this time), and it actually looked exactly as it had back then. I do realize all this likely seems a little stalker-y, but I’ve been wholly open about it, so it’s really not

that bad. I got my hands on their home phone number, so I left them a voicemail earlier today. I introduced myself, explained that I used to live in that house, that recently I've been getting hit by lots of nostalgia, which, you know, isn't really a lie, and that I'd love to stop by and see how it was doing, if at all possible. I didn't mention the door, of course; I'm sure getting this kind of request from a stranger is already somewhat off-putting, so no need to also come off as crazy.

Had a brief call with Clem too, he said he's slated to be here by mid-April. Guaranteed he wouldn't miss the flight again too, can't afford to let another ticket go down the drain like that. I asked what he's been up to, and apparently he's been helping out with boat tours. Said it's fun being on the water all day, but that he's planning to quit a few days before his flight, doesn't want to go straight from boats to planes, just in case. He asked, so I reminded him of my address, and he said he'd call once he got here.

I remember discussing boating with Clem back in school too, being a skipper was another part of his whole deal, just something he couldn't pursue at that age. I don't know if he's ever properly achieved that title, and I also don't think he's still skipping everywhere. I can't say if that'd be surprising or not, though I'll find out soon, I guess.

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4/12/25

8:27 PM

I can comfortably touch my toes now, finally. Stretching's paid off. I treated myself with another pasta day. I've gotten pretty consistent at making dough, so I tried out inventing new shapes this time (apparently some podcaster invented a new shape just a couple years ago—I've tried it, and it's pretty good, pretty decent). Don't think I managed to come up with anything

genuinely original, but I still had fun. Bolognese sauce and honey citron tea; a nice, warm day all around. I'll do my best to keep it up, and maybe I'll be able to get my palms on the ground eventually. Wouldn't be anything to brag about, but still neat.

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4/17/25

3:21 PM

I got a call from Clem today. He said he was in the lobby, if he hadn't messed up my address. I headed down. He looked, well, he looked like I hadn't seen him in years. And I'm sure I did too, to him. We smiled, we half-hugged, etc. I offered to help him with his things; he had two suitcases, some backpacks, a satchel. He said he was alright, that he's been travelling light, but rolled me a suitcase when I pointed out the stairs. We exchanged the usual "So, how've you been?"s climbing the steps, and we were both fine, doing just fine, and I think we both meant it, I really do.

I opened the door to my apartment, stepped inside, Clem right behind me. I went to slip off my shoes, told him to do the same, and

"Woah, hey, is this anti-"

"Wait, hold on! Don't-"

Click

When I turned, he wasn't there.

I should be on the other side right now, not writing this, I should've swung the door open as soon as it happened but I- I just couldn't, I can't, I- I don't want to disappear, I don't want to

die, I, I offered to help him, I made him- if his hands had been full, maybe, if he couldn't've reached for it, then- I, I don't know. I don't know what to do.

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4/18/25

8:03 PM

I woke up at my desk today. I don't think I ate last night. I got up slowly, and headed for the door. Clem's suitcase stood between us.

I still couldn't do it.

The phone rang, so I answered. It was Mr. Lark, inviting me over, saying something about it being a small world. I felt sick. I thanked him, and asked if sometime in the afternoon would be alright. He cordially agreed.

The Larks were as nice in person as they seemed over the phone, and they happily gave me a tour of their house. It was all exactly the same. Some things had been shifted around, and there was a new TV, but nothing had changed. Not really.

They brought me upstairs, and Ms. Lark moved to open the door to my room, now her office. I stared on. The door swung open with a slight creak. Just as it should. Just as it had.

I declined the Larks' invitation to stay for dinner, and thanked them again as I left, said that yes, I'd stay in touch, sure.

When I got back to my apartment, the door was gone. The wall behind the suitcase was empty, just as it used to be. I'm not sure how I felt. Though, even if it were still there, I don't think I could bring myself to open it.